

What it takes

Knowledge: You've got to know the ins-and-outs of your database platform as well as the latest upgrades.

Strong sense of responsibility: Databases are the lifeblood of every organisation—small or big. If the DBA in charge of it goofs up or slacks on his responsibilities such as maintenance and tuning, the whole organisation may come to a halt.

Excellent problem solving skills: A DBA has to have good problem solving skills.

Good communication skills: DBAs have to frequently interact with other people in the organisation such as system administrators and even network administrators at times. You have to be in constant touch with the developers whose systems may interface with the database.

Ability to take quick decisions under pressure: As a database administrator, you will have to handle situations, which would seem like the emergency room of a busy hospital.

Time management skills: Database problems can pop up which the DBA has to fix as soon as possible. You have to make good use of the short downtime available to ensure something of this sort doesn't happen again.

Ability to play multiple roles in the organisation: Usually when a database is up and running, the DBA is left with very little work. If you restrict yourself to just databases, then you might find your importance in the organisation diminishing. Therefore, it is necessary that you show yourself capable at jobs other than just database administration.

is in charge of taking backups of data and specific recovery strategies for retrieval of backups. He has to monitor the health of the database and perform database re-organisation at periodic intervals. He is also responsible for monitoring the performance of the database and tune it for best throughput. And if you are a DBA working in a small organisation with a small database, you may even have to do a little bit of back-end development. It is the job of a DBA to study and implement upgrades to the latest releases so that the database is the best and the latest available.

Working as a DBA can get a bit tough at times, but it can be a pretty satisfying job if you are one of the systematic kinds. We asked Chandrasekhar Madathil, a DBA with more than five years of experience in the field about it. He says, "One should be able to withstand strain, work under pressure and be very pro-active to be a successful DBA. Besides these, having sound



The best way to learn is to work on a database that has a multitude of problems

[Maya Ganesan](#)

Database Administrator

knowledge of the database you are working on is really essential."

Why a certification?

There are many DBA certifications provided by leading companies such as Oracle, Microsoft, Sybase, Informix and others. These certifications are accepted standards in the industry and it is a good idea to have a certification in the database platform you want to work on as a DBA.

Certifications increase your bargaining power in the job market while negotiating for salaries. In addition, companies usually prefer recruiting a DBA with experience and a certification rather than a DBA with simply the same experience.

However, it's always better to go in for a certification only after you have gained some experience as a DBA. Says Madathil, "You definitely need to have good exposure before going for the exams. You may clear the exams after mugging up a lot of things but still won't have a clear idea about the entire scenario."

You must have a good understanding of database fundamentals before you start thinking about getting certified. Working under a senior DBA as part of a group will give you valuable insights, which no course can give you. Also, starting out with the database of a small

company can be helpful since this can be an opportunity to learn a lot. The practical experience you gain by actually working on a database cannot be substituted by any course or exam.

Of course, if you have the aptitude, becoming a DBA ought to be easy. Says Ganesan, "I do believe anyone with good analytical and logical ability can learn and catch up pretty quick. The problem is that the IT boom and accompanying ease of getting a degree and a job has led people with no aptitude for the skill set required, into the stream. This is a line that needs a specific trait of intelligence, one that does not always come with time."

It is not necessary to have formal qualifications for getting certified. However, an engineering degree in Computer Science or an MCA or some similar certification would be beneficial when applying for a job because employers prefer candidates who are thus equipped to those who have only a certification.

Certified by Oracle!

An Oracle certification, the hottest DBA certification on the block, can offer you the largest number of job opportunities and some of the best salaries in comparison with all the other certifications. This is mainly because of the fact that Oracle

is the most common and powerful RDBMS available. DBA certifications are available from Oracle for Oracle 8 and Oracle 8i. The latest entrant to the Oracle certification scheme is the Oracle 9i database beta examination, which Oracle is offering now.

Microsoft Certified DBA (MCDBA)

Microsoft offers certifications for its SQL server. To become an MCDBA, you have to pass three core exams and an elective exam about Microsoft SQL Server databases.

The certification is intended for database administrators, database developers and database analysts. It is necessary that you have at least a year of experience on the SQL Server before you can appear for the certification exams. Earlier, certification was available from Microsoft for the NT4.0 platform. However, Microsoft has retired this certification in favour of the Windows 2000 Server OS. They also plan to roll out exams for Windows XP and the Windows .Net Server soon.

Sybase certifications

Although not as much in demand as Oracle Certified Professionals and MCDBAs, getting certified in Sybase databases can be a good career option. Sybase offers associate and professional